

Westminster Walk - Kids

UK Family Tour

The Arch, the Secret Nose, and the Red Road

Look at the enormous curved building with archways cut right through it. This is Admiralty Arch, built over a hundred years ago, in 1912, as a grand gateway. Walk through one of its arches and everything suddenly changes. In front of you stretches a long, wide, dead-straight road, and it's a strange color, a deep reddish pink, almost like a giant red carpet made out of stone. This is called The Mall, and it leads all the way to Buckingham Palace, where the King lives. On special days, flags line the whole route and golden carriages roll slowly down it. It's the road that Britain uses for its very biggest parades and celebrations, a proper royal red carpet, half a mile long.

But before you march off down The Mall, we have a secret to share with you, and it's a little bit silly. Hidden on the inside wall of the arch, at about the height of a person riding a horse, there is a tiny sculpture of a human nose. A real little nose, sticking right out of the wall, that almost nobody ever notices. For years and years, people made up wild stories about whose nose it was and why it was there. Some said soldiers on horseback would rub it for good luck as they rode through the arch. We'll tell you the funny truth about that nose in a moment. So there are two things to hunt for at this stop. A secret nose hiding in a wall, and the reddest, most royal road in all of Britain. Off we go.

The Secret of the Nose

So, whose nose is stuck to the wall inside Admiralty Arch, and why on earth is it there? For years, nobody knew, and that is exactly how mysteries turn into legends. The most popular story people told was that the nose was put there for soldiers of the Household Cavalry to rub for good luck as they rode their horses through the arch, which is supposedly why it sits at just the right height for someone up on horseback. Others whispered that it was the nose of the Duke of Wellington, the general who beat Napoleon, or even a spare nose, kept in case the statue of Nelson up the road ever lost his own. These are all just stories, fun to tell but not actually true. Remember, when someone tells you a tale like that, it's perfectly fine to enjoy it, as long as you know it's a legend and not a fact.

Here's what really happened, and honestly it's even better than the legends. Back in 1997, an artist named Rick Buckley made a cast, a mold, of his very own nose. His actual, real nose. And then, secretly and sneakily, without asking anyone's permission, he glued little copies of it onto walls all over the middle of London. He stuck up around thirty-five of them, and he often placed them right underneath security cameras. Why would he do that? It was a kind of joke and a protest, both at once. In those years, cameras were popping up everywhere across the city, watching people all the time, and Buckley wanted to show that he could stick something right under a camera's nose, so to speak, and nobody would even notice it was there. For years and years, nobody knew who had done it, which is exactly what made people invent all those wild legends. Eventually Buckley admitted that it had been him all along.

Most of his noses have been scrubbed off or have fallen away over the years, but a handful still survive, including this one inside Admiralty Arch, and several more hidden around a neighborhood called Soho, where people still go on hunts to find what they call the Seven Noses of Soho. So the next time a grown-up

tells you the cavalry rubbed it for luck, you can tell them the real answer. It's an artist's own nose, playing a clever trick on the cameras. You know the secret now. See if you can spot it before you walk on.

The Royal Red Road

Now for The Mall itself, that long straight road glowing reddish under your feet. Why is it red? It was designed that way on purpose, to look like an enormous red carpet rolled out toward Buckingham Palace, so that royal parades would look as grand and magnificent as possible. The whole route was laid out in 1911, as part of a giant plan to honor Queen Victoria after she died, and Admiralty Arch was built as its fancy front door, connecting the busy, noisy Trafalgar Square at one end to the calm, ceremonial road at the other. Stand under the arch and look straight down The Mall, and far away at the very end you can just make out the pale stone front of Buckingham Palace.

On really big days, the kind that only happen a few times in your whole life, this road is where Britain celebrates. Rows of flags go up all along both sides, huge crowds pack onto the pavements, and the royal family rides down the middle in golden horse-drawn carriages, waving, on their way to a coronation, or a jubilee, or a royal wedding. Afterward, everyone squeezes down The Mall to gather in front of the palace and cheer, all of them hoping the royal family will come out onto that famous balcony to wave back down at the crowd.

Keep an eye out for one more royal building tucked just off to the side of The Mall, an old red-brick palace with battlements and a clock tower, called St James's Palace. It's over five hundred years old, built by Henry the Eighth, and even though the King doesn't actually live there now, it is still officially the most senior, most important royal palace in the whole country. When a brand new king or queen is announced to the nation, it's still done from a balcony there. So this one short, straight, red road connects an arch with a secret nose hidden in it, an ancient brick palace where kings are announced, and the most famous home in all of Britain, all lined up in a single straight line. Not bad for one short walk. Enjoy The Mall.

When the Whole World Watched

Here's something clever about the road under your feet. Nearly everything you can see right now was designed to line up, on purpose, by one single man. A little over a hundred years ago, an architect named Aston Webb was given an enormous job. He put a brand new stone front on Buckingham Palace, he built the big white memorial to Queen Victoria that you saw this morning, he straightened and widened this whole road, and he built Admiralty Arch at the far end. And he made them all point at each other in one dead-straight line, like beads on a string, so that a king or queen riding out from the palace would travel along a perfect royal runway all the way to the arch. Stand still and look. Palace, memorial, road, arch. One straight line. That was the plan.

Now imagine this road absolutely packed with people. In 1953, a young Queen Elizabeth the Second was crowned, and so many people wanted to watch her golden carriage roll down The Mall that they came the night before and slept right here on the pavements, wrapped in blankets and raincoats, in the pouring rain, just to keep their spot. Some families had three generations sitting together, grandparents, parents and children, all waiting through the cold and the dark for one glimpse of a passing crown. And on that very morning, news arrived that a British team had climbed to the very top of Mount Everest, the tallest mountain on Earth, for the first time ever. So the crowd on this road was cheering two impossible things at once.

And here's a surprise. This royal road has also been a finish line for the fastest people on the planet. When London held the Olympic Games in 2012, the marathon runners finished right here on The Mall, pounding down this stretch after running more than twenty-six miles. The bicycle racers zoomed down it too, starting and finishing on this exact spot, a blur of wheels and bright jerseys. And even now, every

spring, the runners of the London Marathon still cross their finish line right here, some of them sprinting, some of them barely crawling, all of them exhausted and happy.

So this isn't just a road. It's a stage, built for the biggest days a country ever has. Crowns and carriages, Olympic champions, marathon heroes. Picture them all as you walk. You are strolling straight down the middle of the most famous parade route in Britain.

The Grand Old Duke and Other Surprises

As you walk down The Mall, keep your eyes busy, because there are treasures hiding in plain sight. Look off to your right, up a flight of stone steps, and you'll spot a very tall stone column with the statue of a man standing on top, high above the rooftops. Do you know the song about the grand old Duke of York, who had ten thousand men, and he marched them up to the top of the hill, and he marched them down again? Well, people say that is him, right up there. His name was Prince Frederick, and this column was built for him in the 1830s. It stands about a hundred and thirty-eight feet tall, and it's hollow inside, with a secret spiral staircase of a hundred and sixty-eight steps winding all the way up to the top.

Now here's a cheeky story, and remember it's really more of a joke than a true fact. The Duke owed an enormous amount of money to all sorts of people when he died. So Londoners joked that they had built his column so ridiculously tall on purpose, to lift him up out of reach of everybody he owed money to. That isn't really the reason, but people still chuckle about it today.

Look up now at the trees shading the road. These are London plane trees, and on a hot day like this one they are your best friends, throwing cool green shade right across the pavement. Planes are the toughest trees in the whole city. They actually peel off their own bark in patches, like flaky skin, to shed the dirty city soot and keep breathing. That's why they thrive in a smoky, dusty city where other trees would choke.

And one last secret, about the road itself. Hundreds of years ago, long before any carriages, this was not a road at all. It was a long, narrow lane where people played a game called pall-mall. You would swing a big wooden mallet and whack a hard little boxwood ball all the way down the alley, trying to send it through an iron hoop hanging in the air at the far end, using as few whacks as you possibly could, a bit like a mix of golf and croquet. That old game gave this road its funny name, The Mall. So you are really walking straight down a giant, ancient, royal games alley. Keep spotting as you go.

Pelicans, Lions and a One-Armed Hero

Two animal stops now. First, St James's Park, the oldest royal park in London, home to one of the city's oddest traditions: pelicans. Huge white pelicans have lived here since 1664, when the Russian ambassador gave some to King Charles the Second as a present, and ambassadors have kept topping up the flock ever since. They get fresh fish every afternoon, but they freelance too — one pelican became world-famous when tourists filmed it calmly swallowing a whole pigeon. The pelicans like to sit on the benches next to people, completely unbothered. Then, Trafalgar Square, guarded by four gigantic bronze lions. They were sculpted by Sir Edwin Landseer, a painter who had never sculpted before — it took him so long that people wrote jokes about it in the newspapers, and the lions arrived nine years late. Look closely: their backs are the wrong shape, because real lions can't lie belly-down with a straight back like a dog, but Landseer's lion model reportedly wasn't very cooperative. Climbing on the lions is a London tradition. High above them, on a column fifty-two meters tall, stands Admiral Nelson — the one-armed, one-eyed sailor whose coat with the bullet hole you saw in Greenwich. The square is named after his greatest victory: Trafalgar.

Related listening: Nelson's coat is at Greenwich; his column and lions preside over Trafalgar Square. Listen back — “Nelson's Coat and a Ball That Tells Time” (Greenwich, Day 4).

Duck Island and the Pelican's Amazing Pouch

Look across the lake here in St James's Park and you will see a little wild island covered in trees and reeds. It is called Duck Island, and it is a secret bird city right in the middle of London. People are not allowed to go there. It belongs entirely to the birds, hundreds of them, ducks and geese and herons and of course the famous pelicans, all nesting and squabbling and raising their babies just a few steps from one of the busiest cities on Earth. There is even a pretty little cottage at the edge of the island where, long ago, a birdkeeper lived, and a real birdkeeper still looks after all these creatures today.

Now, about that pelican's beak. Have you noticed the stretchy bag of skin hanging under its long beak? That pouch is one of the most amazing tools in the whole animal kingdom. A pelican does not spear fish or chew them. Instead it opens its enormous beak underwater and scoops, like a fishing net made of skin, catching fish and water all together. Then it tips its head, lets the water drain out of the sides, and swallows the fish whole. That pouch can hold more water than its own stomach, gallons of it, far more than you could drink in a day.

There is a funny old poem about exactly this. It goes: “A wonderful bird is the pelican, his beak can hold more than his belly can.” And it is completely true. That is why a hungry pelican here once managed to swallow a whole pigeon, feathers and all, because if it fits in the net, down it goes.

Watch how calm they are. Pelicans here will waddle right up beside people and flop down on a bench as if they own it, which, honestly, they sort of do. They have lived in this park for far longer than any person you will ever meet, longer than your grandparents, longer than their grandparents, all the way back to a gift from a faraway ambassador hundreds of years ago. So say a polite hello. You are the visitor here. The pelicans are the locals, and they know it.

Dinner on Top of a Column

Look all the way up Nelson's Column, past the lions, past the stone, to the tiny figure of the admiral standing right at the top. Now imagine having your dinner up there. Because that actually happened. In 1843, just before Nelson's statue was lifted into place, a group of workmen and a few brave gentlemen

climbed all the way up and ate a proper dinner on the flat platform at the very top, more than fifty metres in the air, where the statue was about to stand. Fourteen people, a table, and a meal, balanced in the sky above London. After that day, no one has ever stood up there again except Nelson himself, in stone, for more than a hundred and eighty years.

Down at the bottom of the column, look at the four big bronze pictures on each side. Each one shows a different great sea battle that Nelson fought, frozen forever in metal, with tiny sailors and cannons and smoke. And here is a fierce detail: those bronze pictures were made by melting down real cannons captured from enemy ships. So the panels telling the story of the battles are made from the very weapons of the battles themselves.

Now for a tiny treasure hunt. Walk to the southeast corner of the square and look for what seems to be an ordinary round stone lamp-post. It is not ordinary at all. It is hollow, and inside is just enough room for one person to stand. Long ago it was used as possibly the smallest police station in Britain, a secret lookout where an officer could keep an eye on the crowds and quickly telephone for help if trouble started. People walk past it every single day without ever knowing.

And do not miss the fountains. On a hot day they sparkle and splash, and they were partly designed for a sneaky reason: to fill up space in the square so that huge crowds would have less room to gather during protests. Clever, and beautiful too. So this square hides a rooftop dinner story, pictures made of captured cannon, a police station in a lamp-post, and fountains with a secret job, all guarded by four giant lions who have never told a soul.

The Pelican Keeper's Bucket of Fish

Here is a secret that could make your afternoon. Every single day, at about half past two, a keeper walks down to the edge of the lake carrying a bucket of fresh fish, and the pelicans know exactly what that means. If you are near the water around then, watch what happens. The great white birds stop lounging about, heave themselves up on their big webbed feet, and come waddling over like guests who have heard the dinner bell. The keeper hands them roach and tench and carp and trout, sometimes a herring or a sardine, and the pelicans open those enormous beaks and gulp them straight down. It is one of the oldest daily routines in all of London, and hardly anyone knows to come and watch.

The pelicans here even have names. Right now the flock includes birds called Isla and Tiffany and Gargi, and three more named Sun, Moon, and Star. Imagine having a job where you know each pelican by name and they come when you call.

And here is the truly amazing part. For more than three hundred and sixty years, ever since that gift from the Russian ambassador long ago, no baby pelican had ever hatched in this park. Not one. New pelicans always had to be sent in from far away. Then, just this year, in 2026, four fluffy pelican chicks hatched right here on the island, the very first ones ever born in St James's Park. So some of the birds you are looking at are brand new to the world, taking their first proper swims in a lake older than almost any building you will see today.

Now, pelicans are not always polite. One bird that used to live here got bored of waiting for the keeper and worked out something cheeky. A few miles north, in Regent's Park, there is a whole zoo, and the zoo feeds fish to its animals. So this pelican would simply spread its huge wings, fly all the way across London to the zoo, help itself to a free lunch of somebody else's fish, and then fly home again as if nothing had happened. A pelican thief, cruising over the rooftops, following its stomach.

So while you are cooling off in the shade here, keep half an eye on the lake. If a keeper appears with a bucket, you are about to see a ceremony that kings once watched, performed by birds who have owned this park longer than anyone. Give the new chicks a wave. They have a very long London life ahead of them.

The King Who Kept a Crocodile in the Park

Look around this calm green park, with its ducks and its ice cream and its shady trees, and try to imagine it as a zoo. Because that is exactly what it once was. Hundreds of years ago, long before it was a place for families to picnic, the kings of England used this park to show off the strangest and most exotic animals in the world.

Walk your imagination back to King James the First, who ruled here more than four hundred years ago. Along the southern edge of the park he kept a whole menagerie, which is a fancy old word for a royal collection of wild animals. He had camels. He had an elephant. And, believe it or not, he kept crocodiles. Real crocodiles, here, a short walk from where you are standing, in the middle of London, in a country where the weather is almost never warm enough for them. Nobody is quite sure how well the poor crocodiles enjoyed the English rain.

Best of all, James kept rows and rows of cages full of rare and beautiful birds, singing and squawking and flashing bright feathers, lined up along one side of the park for the king to admire. Those cages full of birds gave the road there its name, a name it still carries today. It is called Birdcage Walk. So the next time someone says that street name, you will know the secret: it is named after a long-vanished wall of royal birdcages, the pets of a king who has been dead for four centuries.

Then came King Charles the Second, who loved this park more than almost anywhere. He added even more creatures, and he strolled here every day among the crowds, feeding the ducks with his own royal hands, which people found astonishing, because kings were not supposed to mix with ordinary folk. He was so fond of the place that it was into his park, in the year 1664, that those very first pelicans arrived.

But here is a rule that shows just how special this ground once was. That road, Birdcage Walk, was so grand and so royal that for a very long time almost nobody was allowed to drive a carriage along it. Only the king's own family, and one single lucky nobleman with the marvellous job title of Hereditary Grand Falconer, were permitted. Everybody else had to keep off. It stayed that way until the year 1828, when at last it was opened to everyone.

So this gentle park hides a wild past: an elephant, a herd of camels, a pen of crocodiles, a wall of singing birds, and a duck-feeding king. You are picnicking in an old royal zoo.

The Guards Who Must Not Move

Look for the soldiers on horseback, sitting in little stone booths, wearing shiny metal helmets with long horsehair plumes and holding gleaming swords. These are real soldiers of the King's own cavalry, called the Household Cavalry, and guarding this exact spot is a genuine job, not a show for tourists. Here's the challenge that makes crowds gather round. The guard and the horse must stay almost perfectly still, for a long time, no matter what happens. People take selfies right beside them, wave their arms, and pull silly faces, and the guard just stares straight ahead, not moving a muscle. Even the horses are trained to stand as still as statues. It takes incredible discipline. They do change over in a little ceremony most mornings, at around eleven o'clock, and ten o'clock on Sundays, with trumpets and clopping hooves, so if you time it right you can watch them ride in. Walk through their archway and you come out into a huge open square of gravel called Horse Guards Parade. Once a year, in June, this whole square fills up with hundreds of soldiers in red coats and tall furry black hats for the King's official birthday parade. And nearby stands a rather plain but elegant old building called the Banqueting House, which hides one of the darkest, most dramatic stories in all of English history. Once, a king walked out of an upstairs window of that very building, onto a wooden stage, and had his head chopped off in front of a huge crowd. We'll tell you exactly how it happened. Ready?

The King Who Lost His Head

Here is the true and terrible story of the Banqueting House. Nearly four hundred years ago, Britain had a king named Charles the First who believed he had been chosen by God to rule, and that he should never have to share his power with anyone, not even Parliament. He argued with Parliament so badly that the whole country split into two sides and fought a long, bloody civil war, ordinary people against their own king. And the astonishing thing is, the king lost. His own people captured him, put him on trial, and decided that a king who made war on his own people was a traitor who must die.

On a freezing cold morning, the thirtieth of January, in the year 1649, Charles was led through the Banqueting House, the very building right in front of you, and out through a window onto a wooden platform built against the wall, where a huge, silent crowd was waiting. Now here is the detail that everybody remembers. It was bitterly cold that morning, and Charles was worried about something. He feared that if he shivered from the freezing air, the watching crowd might think he was shivering with fear. A king must not look afraid, he thought, even at the very end. So the story goes that he asked to wear two shirts, an extra layer underneath, just so he wouldn't shake and look like a coward. He gave a short speech, said a prayer, lay down and put his head on the block, and the executioner cut off his head with a single blow. A great groan went up from the crowd, a sound one man who was there said he never forgot for the rest of his life.

For a few years afterward, Britain had no king at all, and was run without one. But it didn't last, and Charles's own son eventually came back and became king in his place. To this very day, Charles the First is the only king of England ever put on trial by his own people and executed. And it all happened right here, on a platform against this wall, on a cold winter morning, with a brave and stubborn king wearing two shirts so nobody would see him shiver. Look up at those windows and try to picture it.

Statues That Breathe

Standing still sounds easy, until you actually try it. The mounted soldiers here have to sit on a horse, in a heavy uniform, holding a sword, staring straight ahead, while crowds of tourists gather right up next to them. They're allowed to blink and breathe, of course, but they don't chat, they don't smile, and they

don't react, even when someone is being really silly just a few centimeters from their face. It is so tiring, for both the rider and the horse, that these mounted guards get swapped for fresh ones every single hour. Standing that still really is that hard.

There's one important thing to know, so you don't get a surprise. The guards are not allowed to speak to you, and they won't move, but the horses can move, and sometimes a horse will suddenly shift its feet, stamp, or swing its huge head around. There are even polite signs asking visitors to keep back a little, because these are big, powerful animals, not fairground ponies. So you can stand close for a photo, but give the horse a bit of room and don't crowd it.

Every morning there's a proper changing ceremony, at around eleven o'clock, and ten o'clock on Sundays, when a whole fresh troop of cavalry rides down from their barracks, hooves clapping and metal jingling, to take over the guard. And there's a second, quieter parade every single afternoon at four o'clock, and this one comes with a great legend. The story goes that long ago, Queen Victoria turned up here unexpectedly and found that the guards had sneaked off and were gambling and drinking instead of doing their duty. She was so annoyed that she ordered the whole regiment to be inspected every single afternoon at four o'clock, for the next one hundred years, as a punishment. The hundred years are long over now, but, the story goes, they still line up every afternoon anyway. Whether or not every detail of that tale is exactly true, if you happen to be here at four o'clock, you can watch the daily inspection yourself and imagine a furious young queen deciding to teach her soldiers a lesson that would last a whole century.

The Painted Ceiling and the Birthday Parade

The Banqueting House looks calm and plain from outside, all neat columns and even, tidy windows. And that is actually why it was so special. When it was built, around the year 1622, most English buildings were higgledy-piggledy, with crooked timbers and odd, uneven shapes. This one was completely different. An architect named Inigo Jones had traveled all the way to Italy and come back in love with the clean, balanced style of ancient Rome, and the Banqueting House was the first proper building of that kind in the whole of England. People thought it looked amazingly modern and perfect.

But the real treasure is hidden inside, up on the ceiling. If you ever get to go in, lie back and look straight up, because up there is one of the greatest painted ceilings in the world, made by Peter Paul Rubens, one of the most famous painters who ever lived. The huge, swirling, golden painting shows King James the First, who was the father of Charles the First, being carried up into heaven by angels and clouds, as if a king were somehow halfway to being a god. And here's the sad, strange twist you can't help thinking about. Remember that Charles the First was led right through this very hall on his way to be executed. That means, on the last walk of his whole life, King Charles passed directly underneath that glorious ceiling showing his own father soaring up to heaven like a god, before stepping out of the window to lose his head. Nobody knows for certain whether he looked up.

One more thing to picture before you go. That big square of gravel behind the guards, Horse Guards Parade, comes bursting to life once every June for a spectacular parade called Trooping the Colour, held for the King's official birthday. Hundreds of soldiers in bright red coats and tall, furry black hats march in perfect lines, bands play, drums thunder, and the royal family watches, some of them riding in gleaming golden carriages. From an ordinary, empty gravel square most of the year, to the grandest parade in the whole country for one single summer morning. If you happen to be in London in June, that is the place to be.

The Street That Runs the Country

You're now walking down a wide street called Whitehall, and it might look like just a road with big grey stone buildings. But almost every one of these buildings is a part of the government that runs Britain. In fact, the word Whitehall is a kind of secret code. When people on the news say Whitehall decided something, they mean the government did. Inside these buildings, thousands of people are quietly running the army, the money, the schools, the whole country. Right in the middle of the road, look for a tall, plain stone monument standing all by itself. It's called the Cenotaph, and it's one of the most important objects in Britain, even though it is completely empty inside. That word, cenotaph, actually means empty tomb. We'll tell you why an empty tomb matters so very much. Then, a little further along, look for a black iron gate with a police officer standing guard. Behind it is the most famous front door in Britain, a shiny black door with the number ten on it. That's Downing Street, where the Prime Minister, the leader of the whole country, lives and works. And living right behind that door, believe it or not, is a cat with an official government job title. His name is Larry, and he is the country's Chief Mouser. Yes, that is a genuine, real job. Let's find out more about all of it.

The Empty Tomb in the Middle of the Road

Stand and look at the tall stone monument in the center of Whitehall. It seems simple, almost plain, just a slender tower of pale stone with some carved wreaths and stone flags on it. But this is the Cenotaph, and it is one of the most loved objects in the whole country. It was built in 1920, right after the First World War, a war in which so many soldiers died far away from home that hundreds of thousands of families never got a body to bury, never had a grave to visit. So a designer named Edwin Lutyens built them this. An empty tomb, standing for every one of those missing soldiers, a place where any grieving family could come and feel close to the person they had lost. The word cenotaph literally means empty tomb.

Every year in November, on a day called Remembrance Sunday, this street fills up with silent crowds. The King, the Prime Minister, and old soldiers all come to lay wreaths of bright red poppies at the foot of the Cenotaph, and at eleven o'clock in the morning the entire nation goes quiet for two whole minutes. No talking, no traffic, nothing at all. Just silence, to remember. If you visit around that time of year, the whole base of the monument is buried under red poppy wreaths.

Here's a clever secret hidden right in the stone. The Cenotaph looks perfectly straight, with upright sides and flat, level tops. But almost none of its lines are actually straight. The sides lean very slightly inward, so gently that your eye can't see it, and if you followed those lines up into the sky they would eventually meet at a single point, high above the clouds. The flat parts aren't really flat either. They're gently curved, like tiny slices of an enormous invisible ball. Lutyens did all this on purpose, using an ancient building trick, because perfectly straight lines can look a little stiff and dead, while these secret hidden curves make the cold stone feel calm and almost alive. So this quiet grey monument, standing right in the middle of the traffic, is empty on the inside, secretly curved on the outside, and holds more feeling packed into it than almost any building in London.

The Most Famous Front Door in Britain

Behind those black iron gates is a short, ordinary-looking street, and about halfway down it is a plain brick house with a shiny black door and the number ten painted on it. This is 10 Downing Street, and a Prime Minister has lived and worked behind that door since 1735, which is almost three hundred years. Look closely at that famous door, or at pictures of it, and you'll spot some funny secrets. The number

zero in the ten is painted slightly crooked, tilted like the hand of a clock, and it's been that way so long that they carefully repaint it crooked on purpose every time. There's a letterbox that says First Lord of the Treasury, which is an old-fashioned title for the Prime Minister. And strangest of all, the door has no keyhole on the outside. You cannot open it from the street, not ever. Someone always has to open it from the inside, which means there is always somebody in there, waiting, day and night.

The big black gates across the road weren't always there. For hundreds of years, anyone could walk right up Downing Street and stroll to the door. The gates were only added in 1989, to keep the Prime Minister safe. Before that, tourists used to wander up and have their photo taken on the very doorstep.

And now the best part. Living behind that door is a cat named Larry, and he has an official job title, Chief Mouser to the Cabinet Office. His actual job is to catch mice. Larry started work in 2011, after being rescued from an animal shelter called Battersea, and he has now lived there far longer than most Prime Ministers, watching leader after leader arrive and then pack up and leave, while he simply stays put, snoozing on the warm pavement and strolling in and out of the world's most famous door whenever he pleases. Reporters camp outside Number Ten waiting for big, important news, and half the time the only celebrity who wanders out is a fat tabby cat on the hunt for a pigeon. Some people joke that Larry is the one truly in charge of the country. Keep your eyes open for him. He's often right there on the step.

The Palace That Vanished

Here's something hard to believe as you look at all these serious government offices. This whole street is named Whitehall because a gigantic royal palace once stood right here, and it has almost completely vanished into thin air. The Palace of Whitehall was once the largest palace in all of Europe, with over one thousand five hundred rooms, bigger than the Vatican, bigger than Versailles in France. Kings and queens lived here, including Henry the Eighth, the king with six wives. It had tennis courts, a bowling green, a pit for cockfighting, and sprawling gardens running right down to the river.

So where did it all go? It burned down. In 1698 a servant was reportedly drying some laundry too close to a fire, the fire got out of control, and over the next hours the greatest palace in Europe burned to the ground. Almost nothing survived the flames. Just one single building was saved, a beautiful hall that you're about to walk past at the very next stop, called the Banqueting House. Everything else, all fifteen hundred rooms, was gone forever, and new streets and offices were slowly built on top of the ashes. So when you say the word Whitehall, you are really saying the name of a ghost, a spectacular lost palace hiding somewhere under the pavement beneath your feet.

Before you move on, look for one more quiet monument standing in the middle of Whitehall, a tall block of bronze. Walk all the way around it and you'll spot something surprising and touching. Carved into the bronze are seventeen empty sets of clothes, coats and uniforms and overalls, all hanging on pegs with nobody inside them. This is the memorial to the Women of the Second World War. During that war, while huge numbers of men were away fighting, millions of British women did every kind of job to keep the country going. They built airplanes, drove ambulances, worked the land, nursed the wounded, and even broke secret enemy codes. The empty uniforms stand for all the different jobs those women took on, hung up as if the women have just stepped out of them after a long, hard day's work. For a very long time nobody had built them a monument, and this one finally went up in 2005. Empty clothes on pegs, standing for the millions of women who quietly kept the whole country running.

Big Ben: The Most Famous Bong in the World

Surprise: Big Ben isn't the tower. It isn't even the clock. Big Ben is the bell — a giant, thirteen-and-a-half-tonne bell hanging at the top of what's officially called the Elizabeth Tower. The bell weighs as much as two African elephants, and its deep BONG has marked the hours since 1859. Listen carefully if it strikes while you're here: the note is slightly off, because Big Ben is cracked. The first bell cracked during testing before it was even installed. They melted it down and made a new one — which also cracked, two months after it started ringing, because someone used a hammer twice as heavy as the rules allowed. Instead of replacing it again, engineers just turned the bell slightly so the hammer hits a different spot, gave it a lighter hammer, and let it ring, crack and all. That slightly imperfect bong is the sound the whole world knows. The clock is famous for almost never being wrong. The clockmakers fine-tune it in the most low-tech way imaginable: a small stack of old pennies sits on the pendulum, and adding or removing one penny changes the clock's speed by two-fifths of a second per day. The most famous clock on Earth, adjusted with pocket change.

Related listening: From Greenwich's master clocks to Britain's most famous public clock.
Listen back — “The Story of Time: From Shadows to Atoms” (Greenwich, Day 4).

The Bell That Crossed the Bridge

Where did this giant bell come from? It was born in a famous workshop in the east of London called the Whitechapel Bell Foundry, the oldest factory in the whole of Britain. It made bells for more than four hundred years before it finally closed in 2017. And here is a wonderful coincidence: the very same workshop cast another world-famous cracked bell, the Liberty Bell in America. So the two most famous cracked bells on Earth are cousins, made in the same little corner of London.

To make Big Ben, the founders melted copper and tin together into a glowing orange river of metal, hotter than a volcano, and poured it into an enormous mould shaped like an upside-down cup. Remember, the very first bell they cast for the tower had already cracked, so this second bell had to travel all the way across London to reach Westminster. Picture it: a bell taller than a grown-up, lying on its side on a special open carriage, pulled slowly through the streets by sixteen horses wearing ribbons, while crowds lined the road to cheer and wave.

When the bell finally reached the tower, there was no crane like the ones you see today. So how do you lift something that weighs as much as two elephants up into a tower? The workers hauled it straight up the inside, turned on its side, using ropes and muscle, moving it only a little at a time, for about thirty hours. Imagine standing at the bottom and looking up at that vast bell creeping higher and higher above your head, knowing that if a single rope snapped there would be an awful lot of running.

Once it was hung and struck for the first time, its deep BONG rolled out for miles across Victorian London, a city with no cars, no engines, and no sirens to drown it out. For millions of people it slowly became the sound of home. And here is a thought to keep: the metal ringing in the tower above you right now is more than a hundred and sixty years old, and every single hour it still does the exact job it was made to do.

A Secret Light and Four Giant Clocks

Look up at the very top of the tower, above the clock, and find the little lantern-shaped point right at the peak. That is a secret signal called the Ayrton Light, and it has a job most people never notice. Whenever Parliament is working late into the night, that light switches on and glows in the dark. It was put there way back in 1885, and the story goes that Queen Victoria wanted it so that she could look out from

Buckingham Palace, across the park, and know at a glance whether her politicians were still up working or had all gone home to bed. So the next time you are near Westminster after dark, glance up. If that little light is shining, it means that inside the building below, grown-ups are still arguing about the laws of the country.

Now look at the clock faces themselves. There are four of them, one facing each direction, so that no matter where you stand in this part of London, a clock is watching you. They are huge. Each face is about seven metres across, taller than two grown-ups standing on each other's shoulders. The big hands that count the minutes are longer than a car. And here is a detail almost nobody spots: each clock face is not one sheet of glass but hundreds of small pieces of milky white glass, fitted together like a jigsaw puzzle, so that when the lights glow behind them at night the whole face shines.

There is a hidden message on the tower too, written in Latin, curling underneath the clocks. It says, in old-fashioned words, "O Lord, keep safe our Queen Victoria the First." It is a little prayer, carved for the queen who was on the throne when the tower was built, and it has quietly watched over Westminster ever since, in a language most people walking past can no longer read.

So this is not just a clock. It is a lighthouse for politicians, a jigsaw of glowing glass, and a secret prayer in stone, all wrapped around the most famous bell in the world. Not bad for something you might have walked straight past.

The Great Clean-Up

Not long ago, this tower disappeared. If you had come here between 2017 and 2022, you would not have seen the beautiful stonework at all, because the whole tower, all ninety-six metres of it, was wrapped head to toe in metal scaffolding, like a giant in a cage. It was the biggest repair the tower had ever had, and it took five years.

Here is the tricky part. You cannot simply switch off the most famous clock in the world, because people all over the country still set their day by it. So the engineers did something clever. They kept just one of the four clock faces working, driven by a small electric motor, while they carefully took the other three to pieces. That way, from at least one direction, Big Ben could still tell London the time all through the years of work.

Then they did something even braver. They took the entire Great Clock apart, every single cog and spring and wheel, more than a thousand pieces, laid them out, cleaned them, mended them, and put the whole machine back together again like the world's most serious jigsaw. And while workers were up close cleaning the clock faces, they made a surprise discovery. Under layers of black paint they found the clock's original colours from Victorian times, a deep, rich blue. The tower you see today has been painted back to those first colours, blue and gold, exactly as people saw it when Big Ben was brand new.

They cleaned every stone, replaced hundreds of broken pieces, added tiny lifts and safety features, and gave the clock hands a fresh coat of gleaming gold. It cost an enormous amount of money and caused a lot of grumbling, the way big repairs always do. But in 2022 the scaffolding finally came down, the bongs came back, and the tower stepped out looking better than it had in a lifetime.

So when you look up now, you are seeing something rare: a very old thing that has just been made new again. The blue you see, the gold that glints, the clean pale stone, that is the tower waking up after its longest sleep, ready to ring out over London for another hundred years and more.

The Houses of Parliament and the Gunpowder Plot

This huge golden building along the river is the Palace of Westminster, where Britain's laws are made — and where the most famous failed crime in British history almost happened. In 1605, a group of plotters rented a cellar directly underneath the House of Lords and packed it with thirty-six barrels of gunpowder. Their plan: blow up the King and all of Parliament in one blast on the fifth of November. The night before, guards searched the cellars and found a man named Guy Fawkes standing watch over the barrels, with fuses in his pocket. His excuse was not great. The plot failed, and to this day, every fifth of November, Britain celebrates Bonfire Night with fireworks. And here's the wonderful part: every year, before the King comes to open Parliament, the Yeomen of the Guard still ceremonially search the cellars with lanterns — just in case. They've never found anything since. One more thing: most of what you see isn't actually medieval. In 1834 the old palace burned down in a spectacular fire, and this fairy-tale Gothic building replaced it. But Westminster Hall, at its heart, survived — it's over nine hundred years old, with a wooden roof so huge people couldn't figure out how it stayed up.

Related listening: Guy Fawkes, the man behind the Gunpowder Plot, was born and raised in York. Coming up — “The Shambles: The Wonkiest Street in Britain” (York & the Minster, Day 13).

The Hall That Beat the Fire

Tucked inside this enormous building is one room far, far older than all the rest, a room that has quietly watched almost a thousand years of English history. It is called Westminster Hall, and it was begun in 1097 for a king with a wonderful name, William Rufus, which meant William the Red, probably because of his red face or red hair. When it was built it was one of the largest halls in the whole of Europe, and the king reportedly complained that it was too small, that it was a mere bedroom compared to what he had wanted.

Look up, in your imagination, at its roof. About seven hundred years ago, master carpenters built a wooden roof over the hall so wide and so clever that it needs no pillars down the middle to hold it up. It seems to float. It is the largest medieval wooden roof in northern Europe, and carved along it are rows of angels with outstretched wings, watching everyone below. Builders and engineers still travel from all over the world just to stare up at it and wonder how it stays there.

This hall has seen astonishing things. Kings held roaring feasts here after their coronations. And in this very room, some of the most famous trials in history took place, including the trial of Guy Fawkes himself, the gunpowder plotter, and even the trial of a king, Charles the First, who was sentenced to death right here under those wooden angels.

Now here is the amazing part for our walk. Remember the great fire of 1834 that burned down almost the whole palace? And the bombs that fell in the Second World War? Somehow, again and again, Westminster Hall survived. Firefighters once had to choose which part of the building to save, and they chose the hall, and they saved it.

And in 2022, when Queen Elizabeth the Second died, her coffin lay here in Westminster Hall so that people could come and say goodbye. So many came that the line of people, waiting quietly day and night, stretched for miles along the river. They walked through this ancient room, under the floating roof and the carved angels, one by one, in a hall that has been welcoming the people of England for nearly a thousand years.

Green Benches, Red Benches, and a Golden Stick

Inside this building there are two big rooms where the arguing happens, and here is a fun way to tell them apart: one is green and one is red. The House of Commons, where the members that ordinary people vote for sit, has green benches. The House of Lords, the grander room, has red benches. So if you ever see politicians on the news in Britain, you can play a game: green seats mean you are watching the Commons, red seats mean you are watching the Lords. Nobody is quite sure why those exact colours were chosen hundreds of years ago, but green and red they have stayed.

Now, the benches are surprisingly small. On busy days there are not enough seats for everyone, so members have to squash together or stand at the doorways. That is on purpose. People decided long ago that a crowded, buzzing room feels more exciting and important than a half-empty one, so they kept it deliberately snug.

Here is my favourite rule of all. In the middle of the Commons sits a heavy golden stick called the mace. It looks like something a giant would use as a club, all gold and jewels. And believe it or not, the whole of Parliament cannot make a single law unless that golden stick is sitting in its place. No mace on the table, no laws, no arguing, nothing. It is carried in and out with great ceremony every day. Once, a furious politician actually grabbed the mace and tried to march off with it in protest, and it caused an enormous scandal.

And once a year the King himself comes to open Parliament, in a golden carriage, wearing a crown. But the crown is so precious and so important that on some occasions it travels in its very own separate carriage, riding along like a passenger, with people bowing to it as if it were royalty all by itself. Imagine a hat so grand it gets its own car.

So this building is full of these gloriously serious games: green rooms and red rooms, a magic golden stick, and a crown important enough to ride alone. Grown-ups made every one of these rules on purpose, and they follow them, very solemnly, to this day.

A Square Full of Heroes

Stand in Parliament Square and slowly turn all the way around. You are surrounded by statues of giants, about a dozen of them, some of the most important people of the last few hundred years, all standing guard over this patch of grass. See how many you can spot. There's a stocky man in a long coat, leaning on a stick, looking grumpy and determined. That's Winston Churchill, Britain's leader during the Second World War, and his statue is placed so he can glare straight across at Parliament. There's a tall man with his arms flung wide open, caught in the middle of a speech. That's Nelson Mandela, who spent twenty-seven years in prison in South Africa and came out to become its president. There's a small figure in sandals and a shawl, walking with a stick. That's Mahatma Gandhi from India, who helped change the world without ever throwing a single punch. And there is one woman, holding up a cloth banner with words stitched across it. She was the very first woman ever given a statue in this square, and that only happened in 2018, after more than a hundred and fifty years of nothing but men. We'll tell you her story next. All around, people come to this square to march, to cheer, and to protest, waving their signs right under the noses of these bronze heroes. It's a square where history is standing up on its feet, keeping watch.

The First Woman in the Square

For over a hundred and fifty years, Parliament Square was a sort of club that only let in statues of men. Prime ministers, generals, and war leaders, all of them men cast in bronze, standing on tall stone blocks. Not one woman among them. Then in 2018 that finally changed, and the woman they chose was named Millicent Fawcett.

Millicent Fawcett spent almost her whole life, more than fifty years, on one enormous task. She wanted to win women the right to vote. Back then, in Britain, only men were allowed to vote for who ran the country. Women had no say at all, no matter how clever or hard-working or wise they were. Millicent thought that was ridiculous and unfair, and she said so, calmly and stubbornly, over and over, for decade after decade. She gave speeches, she organized huge numbers of women, and she never gave up, even when people laughed at her or told her to go home and be quiet. And bit by bit, she helped win. Women finally got the vote, and Millicent lived just long enough to see it happen.

Now look at her statue. Unlike the others, she isn't posing like a soldier or sitting grandly on a horse. She's holding up a banner, a real cloth-looking banner in bronze, and stitched across it are the words, courage calls to courage everywhere. Those were her own words. She meant that when one brave person stands up, it gives courage to everyone watching them do it. The statue was made by an artist named Gillian Wearing, and here's a lovely detail. Around the bottom of the statue are the faces and names of fifty-nine other women and men who fought alongside Millicent, so that she isn't standing there all alone. She brought her friends with her. It took until 2018, far too long, but the first woman finally took her place among the giants. And fittingly, she's the one holding up a banner, reminding everyone else in the square to be brave.

Meet the Rest of the Giants

Keep turning around the square and you'll meet more heroes. There's Abraham Lincoln, the American president who ended slavery in the United States, standing here in London because Britain and America are old friends. This statue is actually a copy of a famous one in Chicago. There's Sir Robert Peel, who might just be the reason a British police officer is nicknamed a bobby. Peel started London's first proper police force, and people began calling the new officers bobbies and peelers, after his name, Robert Peel.

There's David Lloyd George, a fiery leader who ran Britain at the end of the First World War, shown mid-stride as if he's marching off to give someone a stern talking-to. And there's Benjamin Disraeli, a prime minister who was also a bestselling novelist and one of Queen Victoria's favorite people in the whole world.

Now back to Winston Churchill, the grumpy-looking man in the long coat. Pigeons love to land on statues, and, well, you can probably guess what pigeons leave behind. So the story goes that a tiny, harmless electric current runs through Churchill's head, to give any landing bird a gentle buzz and shoo it away, keeping him clean. Whether or not that's really true, look at where he's placed. He stares straight across at the Houses of Parliament, the building where he argued and led and won, as if he's still keeping a careful eye on the place even now.

And look to the west side of the square, at a grand stone building with pointy towers that is not Parliament. That's the Supreme Court, the very highest court in the whole United Kingdom. When the most difficult, most important legal argument in the country cannot be settled anywhere else, it ends up in there, decided by a small group of the most senior judges in the land. So this one square has the people who make the laws across the road in Parliament, the top judges who settle the laws over here in the court, and a dozen bronze giants watching over all of it. No wonder people come here to march and protest. If you want the whole country to hear you, you come and stand where the heroes are standing.

The Church Where Kings Are Crowned

Look up at Westminster Abbey, this huge stone building with pointed towers and windows shaped like arrows pointing at the sky. It is nearly a thousand years old, and it holds a world record you can't see from the outside. Every English and British king and queen since the year 1066 has been crowned right here, on the same spot, in front of the high altar. That's William the Conqueror all the way to King Charles the Third. Kings and queens get married here too. In 2011 a prince named William married Catherine in this abbey, and around two billion people watched on television around the world. Inside, under the stone floor and along the walls, more than three thousand people are buried, including seventeen kings and queens. There are poets and scientists here as well. Imagine the most famous scientist in Britain, Isaac Newton, the man who figured out gravity, lying under a grand marble monument, and near him the ashes of Stephen Hawking, placed here in 2018. And near the great front door there is one grave that everybody, even the king, must walk around instead of over, the grave of a single unknown soldier. We'll come back to all of them. For now, just look at those towers, and picture a thousand years of crowns being lowered onto a thousand years of heads, all in this one spot.

Related listening: The Stone of Destiny sat under the Abbey's Coronation Chair for seven hundred years before returning to Scotland. Coming up — "The Hidden Crown and the Stolen Stone" (Edinburgh Castle, Day 9). Related listening: Mary, Queen of Scots was crowned at Stirling and lies buried in the Abbey. Coming up — "A Nine-Month-Old Queen and the Man Who Tried to Fly" (Stirling Castle, Day 11).

The Oldest Chair in the Kingdom

Inside the abbey stands a wooden chair that doesn't look like much. The paint is worn, the wood is scratched, and if you found it in someone's attic you might throw it away. But this is one of the most important chairs on Earth. It is called the Coronation Chair, and it was built more than seven hundred years ago, around the year 1300, for a king called Edward the First. Almost every king and queen of England since then has sat in this exact chair at the moment the crown was placed on their head. King Charles the Third sat in it in 2023.

Here is the strange part. For hundreds of years, a heavy lump of ancient rock sat on a shelf underneath the seat. It is called the Stone of Scone, and Scottish kings had been crowned on it for centuries, until Edward the First carried it off from Scotland as a prize and shoved it under his English chair, as if to say, I own this now. The Scots wanted it back for seven hundred years. On Christmas morning in 1950, four Scottish students actually broke into the abbey and stole the stone, accidentally snapping it in two. It turned up months later, repaired, and was returned. Finally, in 1996, Britain gave the stone back to Scotland for good, with one promise. It travels back down to London whenever there is a coronation, so the tradition can carry on.

Now look closely at the chair itself, if you get the chance. It is covered in graffiti. Over the centuries, schoolboys and visitors carved their names and initials right into the wood, and nobody stopped them. One carving reportedly brags that a boy slept a whole night in the chair. Somebody actually spent a night snoozing in the most royal chair in the country and then bragged about it by scratching it into the seat. So this battered, scribbled-on, stolen-stone chair is where the crowning happens. Not a golden throne. A worn wooden chair, with a captured stone underneath and children's names carved all over it. Kings and queens have sat here for over seven centuries, and when Charles was crowned, so did he.

Two Enemy Queens in One Grave

Inside the abbey there is a tomb with a marble queen lying on top, and it holds a secret that would have horrified the woman inside. In one grave lie two half-sisters who could not stand each other, Queen Elizabeth the First and Queen Mary the First. Mary was Catholic and burned Protestants. Elizabeth was Protestant and locked Mary's friends away. In life they were rivals, and each of them spent time as a prisoner. But when they died, they were buried in the same tomb, one on top of the other, and someone carved a message in Latin that means, roughly, partners both in throne and grave, here we sleep in the hope of rising again. Two enemies, stuck together forever.

Nearby is an even sadder story. Elizabeth the First had a cousin, Mary Queen of Scots, and Elizabeth had her executed, her head cut off after nearly twenty years locked up. Yet years later Mary's own son became king of England, and one of the first things he did was build his mother a magnificent tomb in this abbey, grander even than Elizabeth's, as if to say, my mother wins in the end. So the two cousins who were enemies in life now lie in the same church, just a short walk apart, forever.

Then walk into the most beautiful room of all, the Lady Chapel built by King Henry the Seventh. Tip your head back and look up at the ceiling. It is made of solid stone, but it doesn't look like stone. It looks like lace, or the inside of a seashell, or hundreds of frozen fountains spraying out and meeting overhead. This is called fan vaulting, and it is some of the finest ever made anywhere. Every one of those delicate stone ribs is helping to hold up a heavy roof, and it has done so for over five hundred years without falling. The stonemasons who carved it never saw a photograph of it finished, never used a computer, and got it perfectly, impossibly right, all by hand and by eye. Kings, queens, sisters, cousins, enemies and friends, all sleeping under a ceiling that looks like it was spun by magic. That is Westminster Abbey.

The Grave Nobody Steps On

Just inside the great west door of the abbey, in the middle of the floor where everyone walks in, there is one grave surrounded by red poppies that nobody is allowed to step on. Even a king walking to his own coronation steps around it. Inside is a soldier, and here is the strange, powerful thing. Nobody knows his name. After the First World War, a war so terrible that huge numbers of soldiers were never found or never identified, Britain chose one unknown body from the battlefields of France and brought it home in 1920. He was buried right here, among the kings, with soil carried back from the battlefields and a slab of black marble laid on top. He stands for every single soldier who died and was never found, so that every family who lost someone could look at this grave and think, maybe that's him, maybe he's finally home and honored among kings. When a royal bride gets married here, she leaves her flowers on this grave. It is the only gravestone in the whole abbey you must never walk across.

Now for a happier corner. One part of the abbey is called Poets' Corner, because it is packed with writers. The tradition started almost by accident. A poet named Geoffrey Chaucer was buried here over six hundred years ago, mostly because he'd had a job at the abbey, not because he was a poet. But later writers wanted to be buried near him, and it slowly turned into the most famous writers' graveyard in the world. Charles Dickens is here, the man who wrote about ghosts at Christmas. So is Thomas Hardy, sort of. His body is here, but his heart was buried separately back in his home village, and there's a spooky old legend that a cat got hold of the heart first. We'll let you decide about that one.

And there are scientists too. Remember Isaac Newton, who explained why apples fall down instead of up? His grand tomb is here, and over the centuries the scientists who came after him wanted to be buried close by, as if gathering around a hero. Charles Darwin is near him, and in 2018 the ashes of Stephen Hawking, the wheelchair genius who studied black holes, were placed in the floor right between Newton and Darwin. Three of the greatest minds Britain ever produced, keeping each other company for the rest of time.

Reading the Abbey From the Pavement

Here is a secret you can crack from right here on the street, without going inside at all. Look up at the two big square towers at the front of the abbey, the ones everybody points their camera at. They look ancient, don't they? They are the newest big part of the whole building. Most of the abbey behind them is around eight hundred years old, but those two front towers were only finished in the year 1745. That is Georgian, the time of powdered wigs, hundreds of years after the rest. A famous architect named Nicholas Hawksmoor drew the plans, but he died before they were built, so other people finished the job for him. So the part that looks oldest is actually the youngest. Sneaky.

Now let your eyes travel back in time. There was a church on this spot even before the one you see. Almost a thousand years ago, a king called Edward the Confessor built a grand stone church here and it was blessed just a week before he died, right at the end of the year 1065. Then, two hundred years later, a king called Henry the Third knocked most of it down and started again, because he wanted the tallest, pointiest, most dazzling church in England, to beat the amazing cathedrals over in France. That is why the abbey shoots up so high and thin, like it is trying to touch the clouds.

Look along the sides now, if you can see them. Sticking out from the walls are stone arms, like the legs of a spider or a row of flying bridges leaping from the roof down to the ground. Those are called flying buttresses, and they are not just decoration. A tall stone building this heavy wants to push its own walls outwards and topple over. The flying buttresses stand outside and push back, holding the whole thing up. Clever medieval engineering, hiding in plain sight.

One last thing, and it is my favourite. Look above the huge front door, the great west door, and count the ten statues standing in a row up there. They look old, but they were only put up in the year 1998, and they are not kings or saints from long ago. They are brave people from modern times who died for what they believed. One of them is Martin Luther King, who fought for fair treatment for Black people in America. Another is a German named Dietrich Bonhoeffer, who stood up to the Nazis. Real heroes, carved in stone, watching over the doorway. All of that, and you never even had to step inside.

A Church That Still Has a Job

Lots of very old buildings are just museums now. People wander around, take photos, and nothing really happens in them anymore. Westminster Abbey is not like that. It is nearly a thousand years old, and it still has a job to do, the same job it has always had. It is the church where the country crowns its kings and queens.

Think about what that means. When there is a coronation, they carry things into this very building that they only use once in a lifetime. They spread out a special golden carpet, they roll in that battered old wooden chair we talked about, and the whole country holds its breath. In the year 2023, King Charles the Third walked in through those doors to be crowned, and the most secret, most important moment of the whole day happened behind a screen where the cameras could not see. That moment is called the anointing, when holy oil is dabbed on the new king, and it is treated as a private moment between the king and God. Even on live television watched by millions, they hide that bit behind a cloth.

And listen for this if you ever watch a coronation. As the king arrives, a group of schoolchildren from the school next door, called the King's Scholars, get to do something no one else does. They shout a word in Latin, Vivat, again and again. It means may he live, may he live long. Real kids, standing in the abbey, shouting at the king, and it is not rude, it is a tradition that goes back hundreds of years. Imagine being allowed to yell at a king as your official job.

The abbey is where happy things happen too. Kings and queens get married here, sixteen royal weddings so far. In the year 2011, Prince William married Catherine right on this spot, and around two billion

people watched around the world. But it is also where the country says its saddest goodbyes. When Queen Elizabeth the Second died in 2022, after being queen for seventy years, her funeral was held here, and world leaders and ordinary people filled the abbey to say farewell.

Here is the strangest fact of all. This gigantic, world famous church does not answer to a bishop, the way almost every other church in England does. It answers only to the king or queen directly. There is a special name for that. It is called a royal peculiar, which is a funny old phrase that simply means the king's own private church. So this is not really the country's church at all. It belongs to the crown. And it is still, after nearly a thousand years, hard at work.

Red London and the Best Seat in the City

Right now you are sitting on one of the most famous things in all of London, and it isn't a building at all. It's this bus. A big, bright red, double-decker bus, with a whole second floor stacked on top of the first, like a house on wheels. And here is a brilliant secret. The two seats you want, more than any other seats in the entire city, are the two right at the very front of the top deck, up above the driver, with the huge window in front of you. There's no steering wheel, no dashboard, nothing. Just London, sliding straight toward you like the biggest television screen you have ever seen. If you're sitting there right now, well done. You've found the best seat in London.

And notice something else. You didn't need a ticket. If you're under eleven years old, you ride the red buses of London completely free, all day, every day. That's a real rule.

Now look out of that giant window. You are gliding down a street called Whitehall, and everything red that you can spot out there tells a story. The buses are red. The little phone boxes are red. The postboxes are red. Even the sign for the underground trains is red. London decided, a long time ago, to paint its whole world one bold colour. Let's find out why.

The Bus You Could Jump Onto

So why is your bus red? Here's the funny truth. It wasn't for beauty, and it wasn't a law. It was a trick to win. More than a hundred years ago, back around nineteen oh seven, London was full of different bus companies, all racing each other for passengers. One big company, called the General, had an idea. They painted all their buses a bright, bold red so that from far down the street you could tell in a heartbeat, that one's ours, jump on. The red made them stand out, people loved them, and slowly that one company gobbled up all the others. The red buses won. And red they have stayed, ever since, for well over a hundred years.

Now, imagine a bus even better than this one. Once upon a time London had a special bus called the Routemaster. It first appeared in nineteen fifty four, and it had a magical missing piece. At the very back, there was no door at all. Just an open platform and a shiny pole. If the bus slowed down, you could hop straight on, or hop straight off, wherever you liked. On board stood a person called the conductor, whose whole job was to walk up and down collecting the fares and keeping everyone safe. When it was time to go, the conductor would reach up and ring a little bell. Ding ding. That was the secret signal that told the driver, everyone's on, off we go.

Here's the part that will surprise you. Those old open buses ran right along this very street, Whitehall, until the year two thousand and five. Then, on one December afternoon, the very last one made its final journey through London, and crowds came out to wave it goodbye, like saying farewell to an old friend. London missed it so much that clever designers built a brand new version, and you can still ride those today, with their own little open back and a curvy staircase. Keep your eyes peeled out of the window. You might just spot one.

The Little Red Box and the Man Who Loved Big Ones

Look out for a tall, red, upright box on the pavement, about as tall as a grown-up, with little windows and a curved roof like a tiny temple. That's a red telephone box. Long ago, before everyone carried a phone in their pocket, this is where you went to make a call. You stepped inside, closed the heavy door, dropped in some coins, and talked. And here is a wonderful surprise about the man who designed it. His name was Giles Gilbert Scott, and the very same man who drew this dinky little red box also

designed two absolutely gigantic buildings, two enormous power stations by the river with chimneys like factory castles. Imagine that. The same imagination made the smallest red box in London and some of the biggest buildings on the riverside. And his grandfather was a famous architect too, who designed a spectacular railway station that looks like a fairy-tale palace. A whole family of builders.

Now watch for another red box, a fatter, rounder one, standing on the pavement with a slot in the side. That's a postbox, where you slide in letters to be carried across the whole country. Here's a good one. The idea of these standing red postboxes in Britain came partly from a man who wrote adventure novels. His day job was working for the post office, and he was sent to some small islands to solve a puzzle. How do people post a letter when the post office is shut and far away? His answer was to plant a strong iron box right there in the street, always open, always waiting. That was way back in the eighteen fifties, and those red boxes have been standing on British streets ever since, quietly swallowing letters. So the next time you spot a red box on a corner, remember. It might have been dreamed up by a storyteller.

Steam Trains Underground and the Cleverest Drivers Alive

Have you spotted the red circle with a blue bar across it? A red ring, like a doughnut, with a straight blue line through the middle and a word written on it. That's the sign for the underground trains, and Londoners call it the roundel. It's more than a hundred years old, and it's so clever and simple that it turns up everywhere, on every single station, guiding people home. Once you start looking for it, you'll see it all over London.

Now, here's something amazing about the very train you rode this morning to get here. London built the world's first underground railway, the first city anywhere on the whole planet to run trains in tunnels beneath the streets. It opened way back in eighteen sixty three, more than a hundred and sixty years ago. But wait, because this is the wild part. Back then, there was no electricity for the trains. So the trains that puffed through those dark tunnels were steam trains, real ones, with fire and smoke. Can you picture it? Roaring steam engines, thundering along underground, filling the tunnels with smoke, while passengers coughed and peered out of tiny windows. The line you rode this morning, the District line, is one of the oldest of them all, opened just a few years after that very first one. You were riding through history and you didn't even know it.

One last red-London wonder. Look out for a black cab, one of those chunky, round-topped London taxis. The driver of that cab has one of the most incredible brains in the city. To drive a black cab, you have to pass a test so hard it's simply called the Knowledge. You have to memorise, by heart, twenty five thousand streets, and thousands of routes across London, until you can find any address without ever glancing at a map. It takes people around three or four years of studying, often riding around on a little scooter with a map clipped to the handlebars, learning every twist and turn. So if you ask a black cab driver to take you somewhere, remember. The whole map of London is tucked away inside their head.